Loose Woman and You Bring Out the Mexican in Me

By Sandra Cisneros

Amorcito Corazón (p. 52) ***Sweetie Heart***

Ya no eres	***You are no longer***
mi amorcito	***my sweetie,***
¿verdad?	***are you?***
ya lo supe.	***I already knew it.***
ya lo sé.	***Already you know***
Fuiste	***You were***
y ya no eres.	***And you are no longer.***
Fuimos	***We were***
y se acabó.	***And it's over.***
¿Cómo les diría?	***How you say?***
¿Cómo se explica?	***How is it explained?***
Te conocí	***I met you***
¿y ahora?	***and now?***
no.	***not.***

**Introduction suggested by Heidi Trevithic of Denver, Colorado, and used for the CO State Finalist presentation*

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INTRODUCTION

To understand the meaning behind these poems, it is essential to know a little about the poet's background. Sandra Cisneros was born and raised in the Midwest, to a Mexican father and a Mexican-American mother. The only daughter of seven children, she and her family lived alternately in Chicago and Mexico City, in poor neighborhoods where American culture became interspersed with her family's Mexican heritage.

Loose Woman by Sandra Cisneros is at once a self-portrait and a statement of defiance. In it, Cisneros acknowledges how others see her and simultaneously rejects and accepts those assumptions. The world has mistaken her as a bitch, a beast, a macha, while she views herself as a fiercely independent and strong woman

Loose Woman (pp. 112-115)

They say I'm a beast.

And feast on it. When all along

I thought that's what a woman was.

They say I'm a bitch.

Or witch. I've claimed

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the same and never winced.

They say I'm a macha, hell on wheels,
viva-la-vulva, fire and brimstone,
man-hating, devastating,
boogey-woman lesbian.
Not necessarily,
but I like the compliment.

The mob arrives with stones and sticks
to maim and lame and do me in.
All the same, when I open my mouth,
they wobble like gin.

Diamonds and pearls
tumble from my tongue.
Or toads and serpents.
Depending on the mood I'm in.

I like the itch I provoke.
The rustle of rumor

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like crinoline.

I am the woman of myth and bullshit.
(True. I authored some of it.)
I built my house of ill repute.
Brick by brick. Labored,
loved and masoned it.

I live like so.
Heart as sail, ballast, rudder, bow.
Rowdy. Indulgent to excess.
My sin and success—
I think of me to gluttony.

By all accounts I am
a danger to society.
I'm Pancha Villa.

I break laws,
upset the natural order,
anguish the Pope and make fathers cry.

I am beyond the jaw of law.

I'm la desperada, most-wanted public enemy.

My happy picture grinning from the wall.

I strike terror among the men.

I can't be bothered what they think.

Que se vayan a la ching chang chong!

For this, the cross, the Calvary.

In other words, I'm anarchy.

I'm an aim-well,

shoot-sharp,

sharp-tongued,

sharp-thinking,

fast-speaking,

foot-loose,

loose-tongued,

let-loose,

woman-on-the-loose

loose woman.

Beware, honey.

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I'm Bitch. Beast. Macha.

Wachale!

Ping! Ping! Ping!

I break things.

TRANSITION

Cisneros at once embraces and redefines the notion of Mexican womanhood while creating a compelling lyricism in her writing. Through her writing, she is telling the world to watch out, stand back, don't get in my way. You Bring Out the Mexican in Me . . . .

You Bring Out the Mexican in Me (pp. 4 – 6)

**NOTE – words in blue italics are defined in the glossary at the end of this selection*

You bring out the Mexican in me.

The hunkered thick dark spiral.

The core of a heart howl.

The bitter bile.

The tequila *lagrímas* on Saturday all

through next weekend Sunday.

You are the one I'd let go the other loves for,

surrender my one-woman house.

Allow you red wine in bed,

even with my vintage lace linens.

Maybe. Maybe.

For you.

You bring out the *Dolores del Río* in me.

The Mexican spitfire in me.

The raw *navajas*, glint and passion in me.

The raise Cain and dance with the rooster-footed devil

in me.

The spangled sequin in me.

The eagle and serpent in me.

The *mariachi* trumpets of the blood in me.

The Aztec love of war in me.

The fierce *obsidian* of the tongue in me.

the *berrinchuda, bien-cabrona* in me.

The Pandora's curiosity in me.

The pre-Columbian death and destruction in me.

The rainforest disaster, nuclear threat in me.

The fear of fascists in me.

Yes, you do. Yes, you do.

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You bring out the colonizer in me.

The holocaust of desire in me.

The Mexico City '85 earthquake in me.

The *Popocatepetl/Ixtaccíhuatl* in me.

The tidal wave of recession in me.

The *Agustín Lara* hopeless romantic in me.

The *barbacoa taquitos* on Sunday in me.

The cover the mirrors with cloth in me.

Sweet twin. My wicked other,

I am the memory that circles your bed nights,

that tugs you taut as moon tugs ocean.

I claim you all mine,

arrogant as Manifest Destiny.

I want to rattle and rent you in two.

I want to defile you and raise hell.

I want to pull out the kitchen knives,

dull and sharp, and whisk the air with crosses.

Me sacas lo mexicana en mi,

like it or not, honey.

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You bring out the *Uled-Nayl* in me.

The stand-back-white-bitch in me.

The switchblade in the boot in me.

The Acapulco cliff diver in me.

The *Flecha Roja* mountain disaster in me.

The *dengue fever* in me.

The *¡Alarma!* murderess in me.

I could kill in the name of you and think

it worth it. Brandish a fork and terrorize rivals,

female and male, who loiter and look at you,

languid in your light. Oh,

I am evil. I am the filth goddess *Tlazoltéotl.*

I am the swallower of sins.

The lust goddesss without guilt.

The delicious debauchery. You bring out

the primordial exquisiteness in me.

The nasty obsession in me.

The corporal and venial sin in me.

the original transgression in me.

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Red *ocher*. Yellow ocher. Indigo. *Cochineal*.

Piñón. Copal. Sweetgrass. Myrrh.

All you saints, blessed and terrible,

Virgen de Guadalupe, diosa Coatlicue,

I invoke you.

Quiero ser tuya. Only yours. Only you.

Quiero amarte. *Atarte*. *Amarrarte*.

Love the way a Mexican woman loves. Let

me show you. Love the only way I know how.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sandra Cisneros
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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
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GLOSSARY

- *lagrímas*--tears
- *Dolores del Río*--Mexican actress who appeared in both Mexican and American films, from the '20s-'70s
- *navajas*--pocket knives
- *mariachi*--a group of Mexican musicians, usually composed of a trumpet and various string instruments
- *obsidian*--A usually black or banded, hard volcanic glass formed by rapid cooling of lava, often found in Mexico
- *berrinchuda, bien-cabrona*
  Mexico City '85 earthquake--two earthquakes (8.1 and 7.5) hit the city in two days, deaths were estimated from 5-10,000
- *Popocatepetl*--"Smoking Mountain", Aztec name given to the active volcano located SW of Mexico City
- *Ixtaccíhuatl*--"Sleeping Woman", Aztec name for a volcano close to Popocateptl
- *Agustín Lara*--1896-1970, musican
- *barbacoa taquitos*--barbecued tacos
- *Me sacas lo mexicana en mi*--You bring out the Mexican in me
- *Uled-Nayl*--a dance of Arab women, especially Algerian
- *Flecha Roja* -- mountain disaster
- *dengue fever*-- an infectious disease of the tropics transmitted by mosquitoes and characterized by rash and aching head and joints
- *¡Alarma!*--alarm
- *Tlazoltéotl*--"Filth Deity", Aztec goddess who represented sexual impurity and sinful behaviour; she was an important and complex earth-mother goddess.
- *ocher*--Any of several earthy mineral oxides of iron occurring in yellow, brown, or red and used as pigments
- *Cochineal*--a vivid red
- *Piñón*--a pine seed
- *Copal*--a resin of recent or fossil origin, obtained from various tropical trees and used in certain varnishes
- *Virgen de Guadalupe*--patron saint of Mexico
- *diosa Coatlicue*--Aztec Earth Goddess of life and death
- *Quiero ser tuya*--I want to be yours
- *Quiero amarte*--I want to love you
- *Atarte*--to tie you
- *Amarrarte*--to tie you

This site may help with the correct pronunciation of Mexican words:

http://www.forvo.com/word/mexican/

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